At the same time, in the aggregate and by virtue of its large population, India has potential and capabilities that few other countries can match. It enjoys the technical and scientific capabilities that enable a nuclear deterrent and a world-class space programme. It can offer massive scale, whether the size of its military, the growth of its civil aviation sector, its digital ecosystem, or its energy and agricultural production. India is home to more billionaires than any other economy after the United States and China. While on average Indian incomes, health metrics, or educational standards may not yet be at global standards, it has long offered pockets of world class excellence in terms of business, medicine, scientific research, manufacturing, innovation, and scholarship. It will soon be the world's third-largest economy, although well behind the United States and China for the foreseeable future. Narrowing that gap will present a medium-term challenge. But the paradox of Indian power is that it is simultaneously both a developing economy and enjoys many of the advantages of a major power. These features are not contradictory—and may even be used to complement one another.

India derives considerable benefits from international partnerships. The world presents India with many opportunities. One, India can attract foreign financing, including state-backed, multilateral, and private investment and loans. Investment can be both direct (e.g. foreign direct investment or FDI) or indirect (e.g. portfolio) investment. Two, India can gain knowledge and technology through research and development collaboration, educational exchanges, training programmes, and joint ventures. Three, it can learn best practices from other countries and systems. Four, India can source critical commodities—such as energy, agricultural products, or other raw materials —that it cannot produce domestically. Having privileged diplomatic relations with source countries is especially helpful when those commodities are highly sought after. Five, it can gain access to export markets, which would both create jobs at home and help lower costs for domestic consumers. Beyond exports, the competitiveness of Indian businesses in foreign environments strengthens the corporate sector at home. Six, India derives earnings and other advantages from foreign labour